



DEATH BY MEETING

A Leadership Fable About Solving the Most Painful Problem in Business

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The Big “So What”

Meetings are an essential part of our work. Great meetings help people to pool resources and knowledge to solve problems and make sound decisions. However, bad meetings are painful, a waste of time and resources, and lead to bad decisions. **This book offers a simple, practical solution to making your meetings more effective and enjoyable.**

The Fable

Lencioni uses a fable to illustrate the dynamics behind meetings, and how they can affect organizational outcomes.

The story is set in Yip Software, a company that creates and markets creative, realistic sports games. Casey McDaniel is the founder and CEO of Yip. He’s a likeable man with a good sense of what the market wants. The company, Yip, is stable with capable employees and cordial staff relations. However, the employees clearly lack passion and drive, and the company is not performing at its full potential.

As the story unfolds, we realize that Casey’s executive meetings are terrible. Although the meetings end punctually every week, nothing substantial is achieved in the 2 hours.

- The agenda includes every area of the company (from budgets to strategy, training and marketing), and there’s never enough time to cover everything in full;
- Controversial or strategic issues are glossed over or deferred, as the executives try to avoid conflict and there’s no time to discuss the problems in detail. Instead, the discussions tend to drift without focus, and time is wasted on small talk and non-essential issues.

KEY QUOTES

“For those organizations that can make the leap from painful meetings to productive ones, the rewards are enormous. Higher morale, faster and better decisions, and inevitably, greater results.”

“The hard truth is, bad meetings almost always lead to bad decisions, which is the best recipe for mediocrity.”

- All the executives dread the meetings, and find excuses to come late or skip as much of it as possible. Yet, everyone is resigned that that's the way things are.

In fact, **the poorly-run executive meetings reflect the underlying culture and state of the company**: Yip's staff are comfortable with their niche and that targets will be met, and there's a general lack of urgency to move the business to the next level.

Things take a turn when Yip is acquired by Playsoft, the second-largest video game maker in the country. Suddenly, Casey finds himself at risk of losing his job, and needs to prove that he can get his meetings ontrack. **With the help of his temporary assistant, they find a way to transform their meetings to become productive and energizing.**

A Model for Effective Meetings



The Paradox of Meetings



Most of us face this dilemma with meetings: they are critical to our work, yet we dread meetings as they're draggy and often useless.

If you're asked to choose between a 2-hour movie and a 2-hour meeting, you'll almost certainly choose a movie. Yet, **meetings should be no less interesting than movies because**:



Movies are passive, whereas **meetings are interactive**. You can't interrupt the actors or the plot in a movie, but you can engage in a discussion at a meeting and shape the outcome; and



Movies don't affect our lives, whereas the decisions from **meetings directly impact what we do** after the meeting, or how we spend our time and effort.

Whether a meeting is productive or energizing doesn't depend on its duration. After all, you can sit through a good movie for hours, and even re-watch it many times. Using the analogy of movies/TV, Lencioni explains the **2 real problems behind meetings: they are boring and ineffective.**

KEY QUOTES

"Bad meetings at the executive level usually indicated a huge gap between performance and potential."

"How is it that we can enjoy one activity that is inherently passive and irrelevant, and loathe another that is interactive and relevant?"

Problem #1: Meetings are Boring

Solution: Overcome the lack of Drama and Conflict

 **Why meetings are boring:** Most meetings are monotonous and draggy because they lack drama and conflict.

- Movies and TV programs are engaging because they come with drama and conflict. These keep us at the edge of our seats, anxiously awaiting to see how the situation or problem will be resolved.
- Organizations come with natural conflict, since people have different views, ideas, roles and priorities. However, meetings become boring because leaders try to avoid conflict and stick to meeting schedules, rather than take time to unearth differences and encourage constructive debate and solutions.

To make meetings interesting/ energizing, create a “hook” and mine for conflict:

 **Use the Hook:** The first 10 minutes of a movie are the most crucial, because it determines if you catch or lose the audience’s attention.

- Likewise, use the first 10 minutes of a meeting to *capture the participants’ attention*.
- Give people a reason to care, e.g. by illustrating how a major competitive threat will affect them/the company, or by highlighting the dangers of a bad decision for everyone in the company.

 **Mine for Conflict:** When smart, capable people come together to discuss an important topic, they will inevitably have different views.

- A leader must seek out and uncover underlying issues and disagreements between team members. Although it’s uncomfortable to confront a problem, it’s worse to pretend it doesn’t exist.
- Meetings become engaging and interesting when there’s constructive conflict and a focused effort to seek solutions.

KEY QUOTES

“Conflict is at the center of every great movie. It is the essence of drama, and it is the reason audiences become and remain engaged in a story.”

“The key to injecting drama into a meeting lies in setting up the plot from the outset... so that (participants) understand and appreciate what is at stake.”

“The only thing more painful than confronting an uncomfortable topic is pretending it doesn’t exist.”

On the other hand, indecision and conflict-avoidance make meetings boring and frustrating.

- To overcome discomfort to conflict, a leader can get real-time permission. You can *announce upfront* that conflict is expected and essential. When you detect underlying concerns from others' questions or body language, *invite* people to voice their concerns. *Interrupt* someone to emphasize that constructive conflict is welcome, e.g. "Before you continue to explain your concern, I just want to highlight that this is exactly the kind of engagement and conflict that we need, to get a better decision."
- The goal is not to reach consensus, but to ensure that all key points of views and contention have been aired and considered. The leader will make the final decision with everyone's commitment to support it.
- This process takes more time, but it delivers a clear, informed decision. This is much better than the issue resurfacing many months later, or having people complain that they never agreed to the decision in the first place.

Problem #2: Meetings are Ineffective



Solution: Overcome the lack of Contextual Structure



Why meetings are ineffective. Most companies only have 1 type of regular staff meeting. As a result, people don't know what topics are appropriate, and bring up all sorts of issues at the meeting

- We have different types of TV programs for different audiences, e.g. headline news are structured and delivered differently from a sitcom or movie.
- Likewise, we need different types of meetings—with different formats, frequencies and duration—for different goals. For instance, you need time to research and debate strategic issues; discussing them at weekly meetings takes time away from urgent, tactical issues that must be addressed for short-term action.

KEY QUOTES

"Everyone, but especially you, as the leader of the group, needs to be looking for places where people have different opinions but aren't necessarily putting them out there. You need to be constantly mining for buried conflict."

"I'd rather spend three hours on something and come to the right decision than spend one hour and get nowhere."

"There is nothing inherently about meetings that makes them bad, so it is entirely possible to transform them into compelling, productive, and fun activities."

Here are 4 key types of meetings, each designed for different purposes:



Daily Check-ins (5-10min). These are like your daily headline news, and should last no more than 5 minutes (or 10 minutes for larger groups).



The goal of a daily huddle is to share daily activities, so you clarify daily expectations and ensure nothing falls through the cracks. Trying to sort out these out individually via emails or phone could take much more time and effort. However, this arrangement may not work for all organizations—for instance, if your team members work remotely or in different locations, it may not make sense to try to coordinate such daily sessions.



The format is simple: each person states his/her key activities for the day, in 1 minute.



For this meeting to be effective, it must be quick. Here are the common challenges and key success factors:

- i. It's common for daily check-ins to start strong, then fizzle out. The key is to make it a natural part of your daily routine. Have *a fixed time and place, and never cancel it*, even if there are only 2 people in the office that day.
- ii. Be disciplined and keep it to 5 minutes. To keep it short, do the discussion standing up (instead of sitting down).
- iii. Try this out for 2 months, then *evaluate* if the arrangement is working.



Weekly Tactical (45-90 mins). These are like your 1-hour sitcoms or TV drama, with a fixed format, timing and duration. The sessions can be held weekly or fortnightly, and should last for 45-90 min (depending on the frequency of the meetings).



There are 2 goals for this meeting: (a) *resolve urgent tactical issues* (including removal of obstacles) and (b) *gain clarity* (by putting everyone on the same page). Thus, everyone *must* attend.

KEY QUOTES

"Five minutes every day would save us countless emails and voice mails and office drop-ins."

 Use this format for maximum effectiveness:

- i. *Lightning Round*: Start by having each person state his her 2- 3 top priorities for the week. Limit it to 1 minute per person. This gives everyone a sense of what's going on, and sets the tone for the meeting.
- ii. *Progress Review*: The team takes no more than 5 mins to update on 4-6 key metrics, to get a sense of their short term performance. Do *not* cover all the metrics, or discuss any of the issues.
- iii. *Real-Time Agenda*: The 2 items above should take no more than 15min. Based on the members' priorities and metrics, the team then decides on the tactical issues they must address to make the week most productive for everyone. For example, "Should we increase advertising this month to support sales?", "Do we need to talk to IT department to get the tech glitch sorted?"



For this meeting to be effective, here are some key success factors to take note of:

- i. *Do not prepare an agenda in advance*. Having a real-time agenda means the loss of some control, but it keeps the meeting relevant, focused and effective.
- ii. *Avoid going into details* during lightning round. Stick closely to 60s per person, and limit the discussion to short-term, tactical issues. If any long-term or strategic issues arise, "park" them aside into a list of possible topics for the strategic meetings.



Monthly/Ad-hoc Strategic (2-4hrs). These are like a full 2-hour feature-length movie.



The goal of the monthly strategic meeting is to deep-dive into critical issues that have a major impact on the organization's long-term success. The duration of the meeting will depend on the number of topics on the agenda.



Choose 1-3 topics in advance, and ideally set aside at *least* 2 hours for each topic, so you have enough time to analyze,

KEY QUOTES

"There is simply no substitute for a good meeting—a dynamic, passionate, and focused engagement—when it comes to extracting the collective wisdom of a team."

debate, and make decisions for each one. Whenever something big comes up at a Weekly Tactical, park it in a list of *potential strategic issues*. You can also get everyone to write down 1 topic, do a 60-second pitch on why it must be discussed, then vote for the item(s) to be included at the next Strategic Meeting.



Schedule these meetings regularly (ideally monthly). If there are urgent issues to be addressed, call for an extra Ad-hoc Strategic Meeting.



The format for discussion should be similar to a feature length movie: Start with a 10-minute hook, then mine for conflict and unearth different perspectives, before heading for resolution.



Here are some key success factors for effective strategy meetings:

- i. Make sure you *schedule adequate time* for each topic, and avoid packing too many items on the agenda. It's better to zoom in on 1 important issue, tap on everyone's inputs to resolve it as best as possible, than to have a "complete" agenda and no time to discuss the items.
- ii. *Prepare and research* the topics in advance, so you can have a meaningful and thorough discussion. You can assign a lead person for each topic—he/she will be accountable for ensuring that members come to the meeting prepared for the discussion.
- iii. The leader must actively mine for conflict; don't be afraid to *thrash out the issues* and debate the issues openly. Despite the preparation, you're unlikely to reach a clear conclusion based on numbers and facts alone. The leader must be prepared to make a judgment call based on the inputs gathered.



Quarterly Off-site Review (1-2 days). This is the equivalent of your mini-series, and would usually take 1-2 days. While 2 days a quarter may seem like a huge commitment, it only adds up to 8 days or 3% of the work-days in a year. When done properly, the payoffs will significantly outweigh the time and resource commitment.

KEY QUOTES

"The leaders of these meetings have to think of themselves as directors. Get people hooked in those first ten minutes, then mine for ideological conflict, and drive it to conclusion."

"You have a passionate, unfiltered, messy, provocative discussion that ends when the leader of the team decides all the information has been aired."



The goal here is step away from daily/tactical issues, and do a comprehensive, holistic review of the company's strategic direction. The topics could include:

- i. *Comprehensive Strategy Review*: Market conditions change rapidly, and you should re-assess your strategic direction not just once a year, but 3-4 times a year.
- ii. *Team Review*: As leaders of the organization, you must constantly evaluate yourselves individually and as an executive team, to ensure you're acting in the best interests of the organization.
- iii. *Personnel Review*: Get feedback on your key employees, from your peers across other departments. This gives you a more holistic view of your team's strengths and weaknesses, and allows the executive team to jointly nurture and retain top performers while supporting poor performers.
- iv. *Environmental Review*: Step back to look at wider trends, opportunities and threats involving your competitors or industry.



Here are some key success factors for effective off-site meetings:

- i. Don't overwhelm yourself with tons of *lengthy slide presentations and speeches*. Focus on what's needed to reflect on and discuss your strategic direction.
- ii. The reason for holding the meeting off-site is to get away from your daily work, and devote your attention to the review. There's no need to waste time and resources on *exotic travel destinations, social activities and silly games*. No amount of team-bonding or social activities will work if the team isn't united by clarity and common goals.
- iii. Don't invite outsiders to attend the off-site meeting as it will disrupt your team dynamics. The only exception is if the invitee is a trusted facilitator who understands your business, and has a vested interest in your team's success.

KEY QUOTES

"Effective off-sites provide executives an opportunity to regularly step away from the daily, weekly, even monthly issues that occupy their attention, so they can review the business in a more holistic, long-term manner."

"Even the best executives can lose sight of the forest for the trees when inundated with daily responsibilities."

Here’s a quick recap of the 4 types of meetings:

MEETINGS	DURATION	PURPOSE/FORMAT	KEYS TO SUCCESS
Daily Check-in 	5-10 minutes	 Share daily activities: get clarity & alignment  1min per person to share daily activities	• Keep it short. Don't sit down. • Keep it administrative. • Set a fixed time & place; Never cancel it.
Weekly Tactical 	45-90 minutes	 Resolve tactical issues + align team priorities.  Lightning round → Progress review → Real-time agenda	• Don't set agenda in advance. • Stick to tactical issues.
Monthly (Or Ad-hoc) Strategic 	2-4 hours	 Deep-dive into critical issues for long-term success.  10-min hook → Mine for conflict → Resolve issue	• Ideally 1-2 topics; give enough time • Prepare & research in advance. • Embrace constructive conflict.
Quarterly Off-site Review 	1-2 days	 Step back to holistically review strategic direction.  Can review your strategy, executive team, key personnel & trends/ environment.	• Go away from office (but not necessarily out of town). • Limit social activities; focus on work. • Don't overload on lengthy presentations/structure.

Getting It Right

Most employees (including leaders) have the misconception that meetings are a waste of time, and a necessary evil at work. They reluctantly attend the meetings, and try to finish the discussions quickly so they can get back to their “real work”.

Lencioni emphasizes that meetings are vital management and communications platforms that all leaders should master. When run well, meetings can provide clarity, alignment and solutions to save time/resources and improve results. When run poorly (which happens in most organizations), the lack of clarity and direction ripple throughout the organization to result in confusion, poor morale and the loss of even more time and resources.

To improve communication, productivity and passion in your organization, get your meetings right.

KEY QUOTES

“When we fail to get clarity and alignment during meetings, we set in motion a colossal wave of human activity as executives and their direct reports scramble to figure out what everyone else is doing and why.”

“Who cares how long it takes if you’re making a decision that you’re going to have to live with for years?”

“Improving meetings is not just an opportunity to enhance the performance of our companies. It is also a way to positively impact the lives of our people. And that includes us.”